Frequent Earthquakes

India is a very different country: what constitutes the exception in more temperate climes forms unhappily the rule there, as any one may ascertain by referring to the meteorological history of that continent for the last half century, within which time only European observations have been regularly conducted. It is a notorious fact that there seldom a month passes during certain seasons of the year, in which the shock of an earthquake is not felt in one part of India or another; not often, we admit, so severe as to crumble cities into ruins. [29]

Rain and Sun

The second of the peculiar local obstacles to which we have alluded consists in the various and uncertain nature of the surface upon which the rails are to be laid .

We need hardly remind the reader of the well-known fact that during four months in the year the whole country is annually subjected to an inundation which covers its surface to a depth varying from 18 inches to several feet, according to its level; as we approach the uplands the continuous rains form water-courses, rushing with irresistible rapidity, and carrying all before them occasionally.

During the hot and cold months respectively, these water courses are dried up, forming ravines, which, in the case of a high road being carried in their direction, are necessarily bridged over.

In general, the traffic roads in Hindostan are merely the dried-up beds of water courses, and when the periodical rains commence, of course travelling by land-carriages ceases. [30]

HOWRAH: THE BEGINNINGS

How Sinking Ships and Land Issues Delayed the East India Railway Operations

The first official passenger railway line in India was opened by the GIPR between the 21-mile stretch of Bori Bunder and Thane on 16 April 1853, with trials held a year earlier. The East Indian line seemed a bit ahead—with 38 miles of tracks in place by 1853—but two mishaps left it without rail cars or locomotives and prevented the running of the first train. It opened formally, in phases, a year later, starting 1 September 1854.

The ship HMS Goodwin, which was carrying the first railway carriages for the EIR, sank at Sandheads near Diamond Harbour, at the mouth of the Hooghly. Sandheads has been documented as a very dangerous area and only an expert sailor could navigate it safely. This left the railways without carriages, and since the arrival of another set would take weeks, they were made locally. This was both faster and cheaper, and the coaches could be